

How Can We Teach Better?

Effective Practices in Inclusive Schools and Classrooms

In this chapter, we turn our attention to effective inclusive instructional practices. As described in preceding chapters, both strengths-based approaches (Chapter 2) and instruction in the regular education environment (Chapter 1) are essential to promoting positive student outcomes. To respond to the question, How can we teach better?, it is important to first establish that students with disabilities deserve, and require, effective instruction. Too often, expectations have been woefully low for both students with disabilities and their teachers. Low expectations, in the form of watered down and disjointed curricula, unambitious learning goals, and few opportunities to learn, have resulted in millions of students leaving school without the skills to be successful in adult life. In fact, students with disabilities have the lowest rates of postsecondary education and full-time employment (Smith et al., 2017), suggesting the need to provide improved education services to better prepare students for life after high school. To counter these low expectations and improve instruction for students with disabilities in inclusive settings, educators must identify and use effective teaching practices that both raise expectations and promote positive outcomes. In this chapter, we describe five effective practices: family-school partnerships, instructional strategies, teaching arrangements, teaching strategies, and technology in inclusive classrooms.

Family-School Partnerships

Family-school partnerships are defined as parents and professionals working together to design and implement education programs (Blue-Banning et al., 2004). This often includes working together to design and implement individualized education programs (IEPs) and monitoring student progress toward shared goals for students. Families are essential team members in these processes.

Partnerships and Why They Matter

Forming trusting, reciprocal partnerships is a critical ingredient in student success; these relationships enhance joint problem solving, communication, planning, and implementation of supports and services, all of which contribute to shared purpose and efforts to benefit students (Hoy, 2012; Newman, 2005). As lifelong allies, family members can also help educators set ambitious expectations for students. However, because parents are usually not as familiar with special education procedures and jargon as are school professionals, an equitable partnership can be challenging to establish (Hess et al., 2006). In fact, many parents report feeling that they are unheard, have little power, and lack information to be effective partners (Love et al., 2017). Therefore, an investment in the family-school partnership is needed to help teams, which include family members and educators, set high expectations and promote positive student outcomes. Table 3.1 provides an overview of essential characteristics of effective family-school partnerships, along with suggested activities for each domain (Blue-Banning et al., 2004; Haines et al., 2015).

TABLE 3.1 Key Characteristics of Effective Family-School Partnerships

DOMAIN	INDICATORS	EXAMPLE ACTIVITIES
Communication	• Sharing resources, such as curricular materials and information about students at home • Clear and honest communication; avoid jargon • Listen carefully • Solicit information from families • Be honest and tactful • Be cognizant of your nonverbal communication	Start the school year by asking families their preferred mode and frequency of communication. Offer several options, including phone calls, written notes, emails, recorded videos, and video conferences.

Commitment	• Encourage the student and family • Be accessible • Be consistent • Be sensitive	Share your hopes and expectations for the student. Be specific and optimistic. Share your plan for achieving those goals and how you will adjust your strategies as needed to achieve the goals you set for yourself as an educator.
Equality	• Empower partners with information and status • Validate others • Advocate for the student or family • Explore all options	Avoid sending home drafts of IEPs; instead, provide families with data about student progress. This enables all stakeholders to have equality in terms of information and status in development of IEPs.
Skills	• Be willing to learn and try • Have high expectations of the student • Take action when needed	Individualize supports and services to students; have a plan for adapting those supports and services as needed over time. Solicit input and feedback from families and other professionals, as well as professional development, to continue to work to meet student needs and solve problems as they inevitably arise.
Trust	• Be reliable • Keep the student safe • Be discrete	Call families periodically to share good news about the student—too often, families only hear about problems. Establish yourself as a person who is a trusting cheerleader for the student and family.

continued

TABLE 3.1 *continued*

DOMAIN	INDICATORS	EXAMPLE ACTIVITIES
Respect	• Value the student • Use a strengths-based mindset • Be courteous • Hold high expectations of students and families • Avoid discrimination	Model language and behaviors that promote the dignity, worth, and value of students and families.

Forming Partnerships

To reap the rewards of trusting family-school partnerships, these relationships must first be formed. Doing so takes both time and effort, but as mentioned previously, the positive student outcomes make the effort worthwhile. Burke et al. (2016) identified three key steps for forming effective partnerships with families.

The first is listening to the family. All families are likely to have previous experiences interacting with professionals (e.g., medical doctors, previous teachers, administrators) that will affect their relationship with you. Be open to listening to those stories, and hear what the family needs and hopes for in their new partnership with you; listen for stories of things that did or did not work in those previous relationships. Your listening also demonstrates your interest in the family and student, as well as your commitment to the student and this partnership.

Working with families to promote meaningful student involvement in and ownership over educational planning and educational decisions is critical to personalized education and inclusion.

Second, establish clear expectations in terms of the partnership. Make sure to clarify your hopes and expectations for the student and your partnership with the family. Be clear that you will seek information and support from others, as needed, to meet these expectations. And clarify how you will communicate, and when.

Third, focus on empowering the family and sustaining an equitable partnership. This means sharing information and ideas and asking families questions. It also means seeking and acting on information, ideas, and insights from families. Maintaining frequent, trusting, and mutually respectful communication will

establish an important foundation for continued family-school partnerships. And, of course, students are part of families, and working with families to promote meaningful student involvement in and ownership over educational planning and educational decisions is critical to personalized education and inclusion.

Instructional Strategies

As articulated in Chapter 1, special education is the provision of specially designed instruction. This instruction should be effective, ambitious, strengths based, and designed to maximize student learning outcomes. How does one know what instruction meets these criteria? One of the clearest indicators is that an instructional strategy is supported by research. In fact, the 2004 Individuals With Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) mandated that IEP teams make instructional decisions based on research. IDEA specifies that this research must reflect regular education environments where children receive special education services and demonstrate effectiveness in improving results for students with disabilities. However, educators must also make sure that instructional strategies are personalized to meet the unique learning needs of particular students. Thus, a one-size-fits-all approach is simply inappropriate. The most complete list of practices educators should use are referred to as high-leverage practices (HLPs). They are considered high leverage because they can be used across different content areas and grade levels and constitute the "common core of professional knowledge and skill" to support effective teaching and improved student outcomes (Ball & Forzani, 2011, p. 19).

The HLPs were developed based on extensive review of the research by experts in special education (McLeskey et al., 2017) and are likely to be effective in promoting positive student outcomes across content areas and grade levels. The HLPs are organized around four practice aspects: collaboration, assessment, social/emotional/behavioral practices, and instruction. HLPs in these four practice aspects are integrated and reciprocal, in that all aspects work together to support teaching and learning. For example, teachers use assessment to design and evaluate instruction in all aspects (e.g., academic content, behavior, social skills), and teachers use their knowledge of HLPs when they collaborate with others. A total of 22 HLPs were identified within the four practice aspects; these HLPs can be accessed online at <https://highleveragepractices.org/about-hlps/>.

TABLE 3.2 Twenty-Two High Leverage Practices (HLPs)

HLP #	HLP TITLE
<i>Collaboration Aspect</i>	
1	Collaborate with professionals to increase student success
2	Organize and facilitate effective meetings with professionals and families.
3	Collaborate with families to support student learning and secure needed services.
<i>Assessment Aspect</i>	
4	Use multiple sources of information to develop a comprehensive understanding of a student's strengths and needs.
5	Interpret and communicate assessment information with stakeholders to collaboratively design and implement educational programs.
6	Use student assessment data, analyze instructional practices, and make necessary adjustments that improve student outcomes
<i>Social/Emotional Behavioral Practices Aspect</i>	
7	Establish a consistent, organized, and respectful learning environment
8	Provide positive and constructive feedback to guide students' learning and behavior
9	Teach social behaviors
10	Conduct functional behavioral assessments to develop individual student behavior support plans
<i>Instruction Aspect</i>	
11	Identify and prioritize long- and short-term learning goals
12	Systematically design instruction toward a specific learning goal
13	Adapt curriculum tasks and materials for specific learning goals
14	Teach cognitive and metacognitive strategies to support learning and independence
15	Provide scaffolded supports
16	Use explicit instruction
17	Use flexible grouping
18	Use strategies to promote active student engagement.
19	Use assistive and instructional technologies
20	Provide intensive instruction
21	Teach students to maintain and generalize new learning across time and settings
22	Provide positive and constructive feedback to guide students' learning and behavior

Teaching Arrangements in Inclusive Education

Upon selection and personalization of effective, research-based instructional strategies, educators must then go about the work of implementing them in inclusive settings. This will necessarily rely on knowledge of the general education curriculum and the routines and activities of the general education classroom. As such, collaboration is integral to effective inclusive instruction. Earlier in this chapter, we discussed the importance of family-professional partnership. Here, we turn our attention to interprofessional collaboration as an essential component of teaching students with disabilities. We then discuss the roles and responsibilities of varied professionals in the inclusive classroom.

Interprofessional Collaboration

Interprofessional collaboration refers to two or more professionals working together toward a common goal. Considering the varied team members who interact with students receiving special education services, interprofessional collaboration occurs between people with different background knowledge, experience, and sometimes values. For example, a speech language pathologist and special education teacher may approach a problem from two very different perspectives, even though they share the same goal of supporting the student. Often, professionals are also stretched for time and resources, amounting to another potential obstacle to effective collaboration. However, interprofessional collaboration can be enormously beneficial to students. For one, the multiple perspectives of professionals may present new solutions that one person working with a student may not have considered. Interprofessional collaboration can also improve student outcomes by integrating the strengths and expertise of several professionals who support one another to deliver instruction, giving the student a team of experts to learn from. Finally, interprofessional collaboration allows teachers, who are being tasked with a wider range of responsibilities in today's schools, to rely on support from others to complete their responsibilities.

Interprofessional collaboration relies on shared perspectives and goals. Educators pool their resources and knowledge to engage in shared decision making toward a common goal. It is a way to accomplish a goal that may not be attainable alone (Bauer et al., 2010). As noted, this process is associated with improved student outcomes; however, it is not always easy for professionals to do. For one,

some educators prefer to work alone—they may feel that others lack needed skills or that it is simply easier or faster to work alone.

When the benefits of interprofessional collaboration are clear and educators want to work together, another barrier can arise: the lack of time and resources to collaborate. Many teachers and related services providers have large case-loads, making it challenging to find time to focus on one student. Electronic collaboration strategies, such as web conferencing and cloud-based document management services, can be used to allow professionals to work in a collaborative way even when they may not have the time to meet together in person or at the same time (Charles & Dickens, 2012).

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Roles and Responsibilities in the Inclusive Classroom

When instructional practices are identified through interprofessional collaboration, the next step in effective inclusive education is clearly defining the roles and responsibilities of the people providing instruction. This is because educators must leave their traditional silos of special classrooms, therapy rooms, or other separate spaces to support student learning in general education settings. To accomplish this, teaching itself will look different. Educators must work together in new ways to provide instruction to all students, including using new instructional strategies and groupings to meet the needs of all learners. For example, high school special and general educators may design lessons that are universally accessible to all students, including use of audio books, videos, and speech-to-text software, by drawing on their combined knowledge of the content and effective instructional practices. Educators will also likely engage in new activities, including coaching, consulting, and collaborating. Because co-teachers will likely have different skills and backgrounds (e.g., one is trained in to deliver special education services and another trained to teach biology), some degree of coaching may be necessary to support co-teachers in developing new instructional skills, classroom management skills, and other skills. Coaches work with other professionals (e.g., teachers, related services

providers, paraprofessionals) to provide resources and strategies that can be used in the classroom. Coaches work directly with the other professionals, often completing observations followed by discussion and problem solving to support skill development and ultimately build their capacity to implement effective practices (Włodarczyk et al., 2015). Likewise, consultation occurs when professionals meet together to discuss a student and offer advice. Using these strategies, educators work together to plan and problem solve, ensuring effective inclusive instruction is provided.

Inclusive education also requires a rethinking in how paraprofessionals are employed to support students with disabilities. Traditionally, paraprofessionals work one to one with students, assuming a primarily teaching role. Consequences of this use of paraprofessionals include lack of teacher involvement in instruction, student dependency on adult support, and barriers to peers and other natural supports, among others (e.g., Giangreco & Broer, 2005). An alternative to reliance on one-to-one paraprofessionals in the inclusive classroom is use of class-wide paraprofessionals. These paraprofessionals are assigned to classrooms rather than students. For example, a paraprofessional may be assigned to third-period biology, in which a small number of students receiving special education services are enrolled (in natural proportions). The paraprofessionals in such a classroom setting are a support for all students; rather than being assigned to specific students, they instead circulate around the room, providing cues, prompts, reminders, and assistance as needed. They will, of course, be particularly available for students with disabilities or other students who may need more support. This support arrangement is associated with many benefits to students and teachers: it facilitates more teacher time with individual students by reducing the teacher-to-student ratio, decreases stigmatization and dependency on adult supports, allows students more opportunities to respond and get feedback from an educator, and facilitates peer interactions.

Peer-assisted learning is yet another opportunity to provide effective instruction in the inclusive classroom. Peer-assisted learning occurs when same-age peers partner with a student with a disability and provide supports for their partner to learn and participate (Carter, 2017). For example, a peer partner might prompt a student to use a speech-generating device, model how to respond to a question, or work with together on an assignment, among many other possible supports. Peers are excellent support providers in inclusive classrooms for several reasons: (a) they know what matters in the social environment of the school

and can help students with disabilities navigate these expectations and provide social opportunities; (b) working with a peer is far less stigmatizing than working with an adult—often, adult supports are real barriers to peer interactions; (c) peer supports are readily available and therefore a good support solution to schools that lack other resources; and (d) peer partners benefit academically, socially, and behaviorally from these partnerships (Carter, 2017). Ideal peer partners have good school attendance and are the preferred partners of students with disabilities; in other words, although adults often create these partnerships, the preferences of the student with disabilities should be sought and included in any partnership decisions.

Considering the variety of new roles and responsibilities in inclusive classrooms, including when peer supports are used, it is essential to clearly describe the expectations of all adults. To clarify the new roles and responsibilities of all educators and peer partners in the inclusive classroom, a co-teaching roles and responsibilities plan can be useful. Table 3.2 offers a template for creating such a plan, inviting educators to identify the major routines of a lesson, the co-teaching and other responsibilities of the general education teacher, the co-teaching and other responsibilities of the special education teacher, the activities of the paraprofessional, and the responsibilities of the peer partner. Also note that this overall plan includes planning prior to instruction, as well as reflection at the end of the lesson. Several of the planning aspects offered in Table 3.3 are discussed in the following sections.

Teaching Strategies in Inclusive Classrooms

In addition to considering the instructional arrangements of inclusive classroom, we now describe the process of teaching students with disabilities in inclusive settings. We consider three key processes: instructional cycles, inclusive schedules, and inclusive instructional plans.

Instructional Cycles

Effective instructional cycles include three components: co-planning, co-teaching, and progress monitoring. As shown in Figure 3.1, this is an iterative process, with each step continuously informing the next.

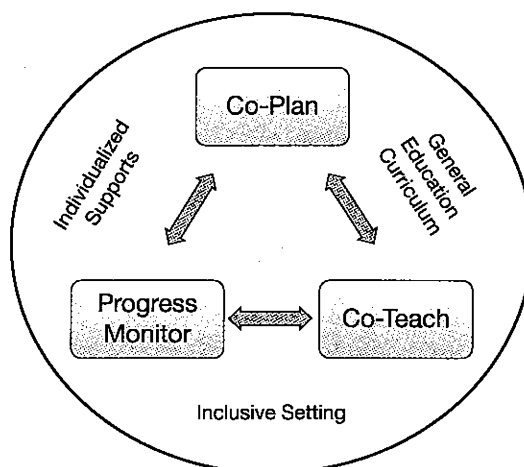


FIGURE 3.1 Instructional Cycle for Inclusive Education

Co-planning

Special and general educators must work together to plan for instructional content, supports, and assessment and be prepared to plan and implement a variety of strategies to ensure the progress and participation of each student. Co-planning is a means of accomplishing these goals and thus should occur regularly, preferably at the start of each unit of study. When co-planning, educators should find a distraction-free time (i.e., not during instruction or otherwise supervising students) when they will have curricular materials available to discuss (Murawski, 2012).

Educators should identify the routine components of each lesson (e.g., lecture, small group work, labs) and identify how instruction will be provided, what content will be covered, who will provide instruction, and how student supports will be delivered (Toews et al., 2020). Planning for a unit of study is more efficient than planning for each lesson, by allowing educators to focus on how they will teach and provide supports during routine activities; thus, identifying those routine activities and developing plans for them prevent the need for detailed planning on a daily basis.

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TABLE 3.3 Inclusive Instruction Roles and Responsibilities Template: Circle Critical Elements for Each Routine Activity for Each Application

ROUTINE ACTIVITIES	GENERAL EDUCATION TEACHER RESPONSIBILITIES	SPECIAL EDUCATION TEACHER RESPONSIBILITIES	PARAPROFESSIONAL RESPONSIBILITIES	PEER PARTNER RESPONSIBILITIES
Planning (prior to instruction)	- Develop lesson plans - Determine needed materials - Align lessons with standards, IEPs - Plan groupings and activities - Identify accommodations, modifications, and supports	- Develop lesson plans - Determine needed materials - Align lessons with standards, IEPs - Plan groupings and activities - Identify accommodations, modifications, and supports	- Prepare accommodations and modifications per teacher direction - Obtain needed materials - Assist in coordinating and managing activities	Not applicable
Whole group	- One teach, one support - Team teaching - Parallel teaching - Station teaching - Alternative teaching - Individual instruction - Other:	- One teach, one support - Team teaching - Parallel teaching - Station teaching - Alternative teaching - Individual instruction - Other:	- Not present - Class-wide supports - Individual supports - Data collection - Clerical - Support peer partner - Other:	- Not present - Social/friendship supports - Academic supports - Communication supports - Other

Small group (labs, stations, centers)	• One teach, one support • Team teaching • Parallel teaching • Station teaching • Alternative teaching • Other:	• One teach, one support • Team teaching • Parallel teaching • Station teaching • Alternative teaching • Individual instruction • Other:	• Not present • Class-wide supports • Individual supports • Data collection • Clerical • Support peer partner • Other:	• Not present • Social/friendship supports • Academic supports • Communication supports • Other
Independent work	• One teach, one support • Team teaching • Parallel teaching • Station teaching • Alternative teaching • Other:	• One teach, one support • Team teaching • Parallel teaching • Station teaching • Alternative teaching • Individual instruction • Other:	• Not present • Class-wide supports • Individual supports • Data collection • Clerical • Support peer partner • Other:	• Not present • Social/friendship supports • Academic supports • Communication supports • Other
After the lesson	• Review student data • Review student accommodations, modifications, and supports • Review groupings • Grading	• Review student data • Review student accommodations, modifications, and supports • Review groupings • Grading	• Compile student data • Assist in reviewing accommodations, modifications, and supports • Assist in review of groupings • Assist in grading	• Not applicable

Co-teaching

A significant benefit of inclusive instruction is the possibility of using co-teaching arrangements, in which two or more adults work together to provide instruction to students (Friend et al., 2010). As noted by Murawski (2012), a variety of co-teaching arrangements are possible (listed in Table 3.2): (a) one teach, one support, when one educator is providing instruction to the whole class, while the other educator provides support (e.g., setting up labs, classroom management, data collection); (b) team teaching, in which both teachers provide instruction (e.g., taking turns, modeling how to solve a problem); (c) parallel teaching, in which one educator provides instruction to one half of the class while the other educator provides education to the other half of the class at the same time; (d) station teaching, in which students rotate among different stations or centers, with an educator at different stations; and (e) alternative teaching, in which one educator works with a large group of students while the other educator works with a small group of students. Educators may use different co-teaching arrangements on different days, different lessons within a day, or different activities within a lesson. In other words, educators can decide what sort of co-teaching arrangement will work best for them, given their unique interests, skill sets, and preferences.

Progress Monitoring

Successful educators collect formative data to measure the effectiveness of their instruction. Educators will draw on these data to make instructional decisions. For example, a kindergarten teacher may collect progress monitoring data on how accurately students rhyme words, and use data to decide which students need to be provided more intensive instruction. This continuous process of instruction, assessment, and data-based decision making is used to ensure adequate student progress in the general education curriculum (Watson et al., 2011). In the inclusive setting, general and special educators work together to collect data, analyze data, and make instructional decisions with this information. As such, these roles and responsibilities should be defined during the collaborative planning time.

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